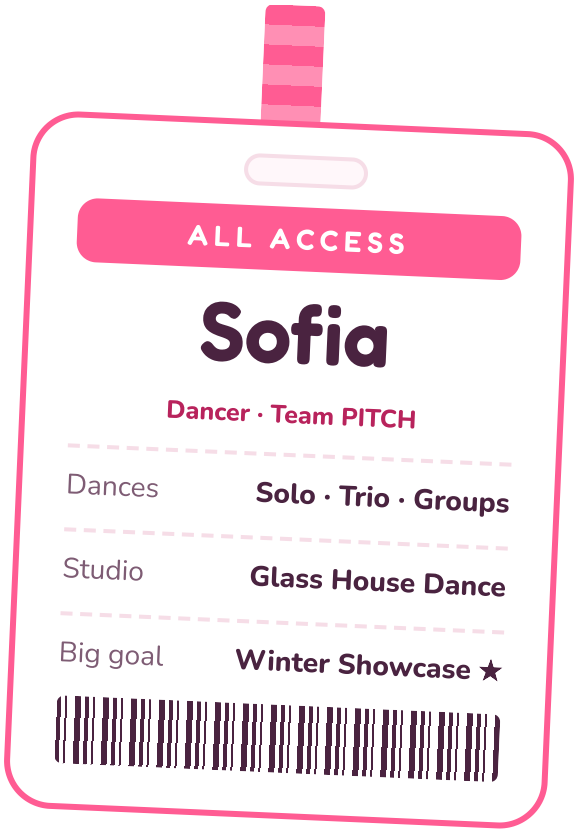
FOR SOFIA · SEASON 2026–27

Your backstage pass

This season you have three helpers: the **Spotlight app**, your **Practice Toolkit** and your **Season Workbook**. Like a stage crew, each one has its own job. Here's who does what, what to grab when, and how to keep dance, school, home and fun all feeling good.



If you remember only five things

- ★ **App = today. Toolkit = how. Workbook = everything else.**
- ★ A little practice most days beats one giant practice.
- ★ A teacher's correction goes into your practice right away.
- ★ Sleep 9–12 hours. Your brain practices while you sleep.
- ★ Dance, school, home and fun each get some time every week.

PART 1

Meet your crew

Three helpers, three different jobs. None of them does everything.

PHONE OR TABLET

Spotlight app

The coach in your pocket

Tells you what to do TODAY.

- **Today:** the plan for today and Ms. Brittany's homework
- ▶ **Start practice:** music, timer and every step in order
- **Your solo:** practice player, Cue cards, Chunks, Pause & Predict
- **Sunday:** film your solo and send it to Coach me
- Stars, streaks and games
- Counts down the days to the show

PAPER · 6 PAGES

Practice Toolkit

Your practice map

Shows HOW to practice and how far you've come.

- **p.1** The plan, the big checkpoints, your week
- **p.2** Tracker: a sticker for every home practice
- **p.3** How to practice + Show in your head
- **p.4** Solo map, your fixes, the trick ladder
- **p.5** Trio memory map and counts
- **p.6** This week: a fresh sheet every Sunday

PAPER · 6 PAGES

Season Workbook

Your dancer's handbook

EVERYTHING ELSE about the season.

- **p.5–6** Group dances: PITCH jazz + contemporary
- **p.9** Show day, nerves, "if it goes wrong"
- **p.10** Music, people, costumes
- **p.11** Packing lists
- **p.14** Count sheets

App = TODAY **Toolkit = HOW** **Workbook = EVERYTHING ELSE**

All your paper lives in one binder

Six tabs, in this order. Each divider says what's behind it.

1 Start here

This guide

2 My plan

Toolkit p.1 the plan · p.2 tracker · p.6 This week

3 Practice

Toolkit p.3 how to practice · Workbook p.14 count sheets

4 My dances

Toolkit p.4 solo · p.5 trio · Workbook p.5–6 group dances

5 Aerial

Aerial Mission: the drills, the plan, the checklist

6 Show time

Workbook p.9 show day + nerves · p.11 packing · p.10 music + people

If two helpers say different things

Your teachers › the app › the Toolkit › the Workbook

Teachers always win. After that, the newest helper wins, and the app is the newest.

PART 2

What do I grab?

Find your moment on the left. The chip says which helper to grab.

What do I practice today?	App Open Today. It shows the plan and how long it takes.
It's a home practice day	App · Toolkit p.4 Tap ▶ Start practice. Keep page 4 open next to you so you can see your fixes.
I finished!	App · Toolkit p.2 Tap Done in the app, then put a sticker on page 2. Three in a week = a full week ★
A part of my solo keeps slipping	App Dances › your solo › Chunks or Cue cards. Learn one 8-count, then join it to the one before.

A teacher gave me a correction	App · Toolkit p.6 Tell Mom and add it with + Note on that dance. Write it on This week. It becomes your fix right away. Corrections from Saturday group rehearsal count too.
It's Sunday	App · Toolkit p.2 + p.6 Film your solo and send it to Coach me. Watch it with Mom: what went well first, then ONE fix. Write the fix on page 2 and fill in a new page 6.
Group dances	Workbook p.5–6 The big groups practice at Saturday rehearsal. At home, only if you got a correction. Their pages are behind the My dances tab.
Aerial drills	Aerial tab Mat under you, every time. First tries happen in Monday Acro with a coach. At home, Mom films and holds the mat.
Packing for a show	Workbook p.11 Show time tab. Use the packing list and pack the night before.
Butterflies before the show	Workbook p.9 Show time tab. Do your "before you go on" routine. Then breathe: smell the flower, blow out the candle.
Show in your head (starts Nov 9)	Toolkit p.3 Music on, screen face down, eyes closed. Dance the whole solo in your head.

PART 3

The big goal, in small steps

THE BIG GOAL

Dance your solo at the Winter Showcase from memory, full out, eyes up, holding the ending to the very last note. And love doing it.

Four parts get you there, one after the other. Don't skip ahead.

1
Own it
Sep 28 – Nov 8

Know every step by heart. No video, nobody to follow. Memory + knees: no new tricks yet.

2
Clean it
Nov 9 – Nov 29

Make it sharp: feet, knees, arms, eyes. One fix at a time. Show in your head starts.

3
Perform it
Nov 30 – Jan 3

Dance it like the real show. Full out, costume on, little audiences at home.

4
Taper
Jan 4 – the show

Less work, more rest. Nothing new. Fresh legs, calm head, early nights.

How big goals get done

- [ ] **One 8-count at a time.** Learn it, then join it to the one before.
- [ ] **One fix at a time.** It's done when it shows on two videos in a row.
- [ ] **A short practice most days.** 35–40 minutes at home is plenty.
- [ ] **Never more than 2 days without your solo.** On busy days, the 15-minute memory run counts (and on Monday, Hannah's videos and picturing it).
- [ ] **Finish lines get prizes.** At each checkpoint, pick a reward with Mom: a movie night, a new scrunchie, choosing Saturday breakfast.

Your finish lines are on Toolkit page 1, and the app shows the next one on Today.

PART 4

Your week

The same rhythm every week, so you always know what's next.

Studio | Home practice | 15-min memory run

Mon

Studio

Ballet · Acro · Jazz Tech

4:30–7:30

Watch Hannah's videos; picture the solo in the car. No dancing tonight. Homework first, early bed.

Tue

Studio

Hip Hop · Ballroom

5:30–7:30

15-minute memory run.

Wed

Studio

Contemporary

6:30–7:30

+ memory run Solo rehearsal when one is booked.

Thu

Home

Strong + bendy + trio + solo

35–40 min

Fri

Home

Technique + this week's trick + solo

35–40 min

Sat

Studio

Co Tech · PITCH rehearsal

10:00–12:15

The big groups practice here.

Sun

Home

Film the solo + trio + film review

35–40 min

Plan your week on Toolkit p.6.

Trio privates with Larisa happen 1–2 times a month. On any day with a class, rehearsal or make-up, home practice is the short one: the 15-minute memory run.

PART 5

Keep all four spotlights on

A happy dancer has four lights. Each one gets some time every week, and none of them should go dark.

Dance

Classes plus short home practices. That's enough. More isn't always better.

School

Homework first on studio days. Read a little every day. Ask for help early, before it piles up.

Home

Chores are teamwork: make your bed, pack your dance bag, help with dinner, and tidy your dance spot in 2 minutes.

Fun

Friends, playing outside, drawing, family time, even doing nothing at all. Fun is part of the plan.

Does it feel like too much?

Always tired, grumpy about dance, a sore spot that won't go away, or worries at bedtime? **Tell Mom.** A lighter day is part of the plan, and the 15-minute memory run is the light version.

PART 6

Time-smart tricks

Same time, same place.
Start practice at the same time on Thu, Fri and Sun. A habit is easier than willpower.

Big thing first.
Homework, then practice, then free time.

Let the timer be the boss.
The app times each part. When it says done, you're done.

Plan on Sunday.
Fill in page 6 and look at the week: tests, parties, rehearsals.

Pack tonight.
Dance bag and water bottle by the door the night before.

Stuck? Do the tiniest step.
Put on dance clothes and start the warm-up. Starting is the hardest part.

PART 7

Screen-smart

The app is a tool.
Open it, practice, close it.

Paper first.
Planning, stickers, reading your fixes and Show in your head all happen on paper or with your eyes closed.

Filming?
The phone goes on its stand at the side, not in your hand.

Screens off 1 hour before bed.
Phones and tablets sleep outside your room.

Screen-free swaps: draw a costume idea, read, play outside, bake with Mom, freestyle to your favorite song, build a blanket fort.

PART 8

Fuel like a dancer

Dancing burns lots of energy, and food is your fuel. Every idea here is fish-and-veggie friendly.

EVERY MORNING

Breakfast

Oatmeal with berries, eggs and toast, yogurt with granola, or a waffle with peanut butter.

1–2 HOURS BEFORE CLASS

A small snack

Banana + peanut butter, apple + cheese, yogurt, crackers + hummus, or trail mix.

AFTER CLASS

Refuel

Chocolate milk, Greek yogurt, eggs, a tuna or salmon sandwich, a bean-and-cheese quesadilla, or edamame.

EVERY DAY

Build strong

A rainbow of fruits and veggies. Milk, yogurt or cheese for strong bones. Beans, lentils, eggs, fish and spinach for energy.

Water bottle at every class. Sip before, during and after. Pale yellow pee means you're good. Dark means drink more.

Never skip a meal. Dancers run on fuel. Growing bodies change and need lots of food. Strong dancers eat well. On show day, eat foods you know and nothing new.

PART 9

Sleep is secret practice

9–12

hours every night

That's what kids your age need. While you sleep, your brain saves the steps you practiced, and your muscles repair and grow.

I wake up at **7:00** so lights out by **9:00 pm** for 10 hours.

Same bedtime every night,
weekends too.

Late studio nights (Mon, Tue):
dinner, the 15-minute memory run on Tuesday, shower, bed. Homework is already done.

Wind down:
shower, PJs, a paper book, lights out.

Show in your head in bed
is optional. It never makes bedtime later.

PART 10

Take care of your dancer body

Your body is your instrument. Here's how to tell normal sore from stop-and-tell.

Normal: keep going

Muscles that burn while you work. Tired, achy legs the next day. A stretch you can feel that doesn't hurt.

Stop and tell Mom

Sharp or stabbing pain. Pain in a knee, ankle, wrist or your back. Swelling, limping, or pain that wakes you up or lasts more than a few days.

- ★ **Warm up first, always.** Stretch only warm muscles. A stretch, never pain. No oversplits.
- ★ **Stop before you're too tired.** Tired teaches your body the wrong way.
- ★ **Rest counts as training.** No dancing at home on Monday (videos and picturing only), and the taper is rest on purpose.
- ★ **Nervous?** Smell the flower (breathe in for 4), blow out the candle (out for 6). Three times.
- ★ **Acro on the mat or with a spotter.** Kick-overs and aerials only in class.
- ★ **Knees over toes** in every plié, lunge and landing.
- ★ **Happy feet:** toenails short, check for blisters, socks off for floor work.
- ★ **Be kind to yourself.** Mistakes are how dancers learn. Say what went well first.

For Mom

Be the stage crew, not the teacher: music, timer, filming, stickers. Ask, don't correct ("What comes next?"). Praise the work, not the talent. More on Toolkit page 3.

Sleep: AASM pediatric sleep consensus (2016)

Screens: AAP Family Media Plan

Rest and training load: Jayanthi et al. 2015

Made Oct 26, 2026. When the plan changes, the app has the newest version.